2026-10-13



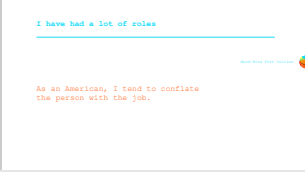
TITLE. Say it, let it sit. Do NOT flip it yet – that is slide 7. The tagline is doing quiet work: ”Be there and be square” is the close, already on the wall, ten minutes early. Nobody needs to notice.

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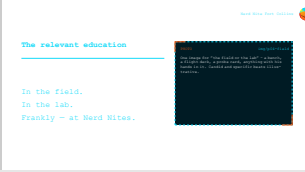


ITEM 1a. His own opening line from the Nerdometer origin story. It is already written and it already works. Warm, fast, do not linger.

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ITEM 1b. His own observation, 12 Oct, and it is the thesis in miniature: a job title is the data, the person is the cognition. Get the laugh on the "as an American" line, then land the last two lines straight. Past tense on the Marine material and it is NOT in the opening position – it is one item in a list that exists to be undercut by the next line.



ITEM 1c. Short. The biggest lessons were not in schools or universities. Do not inventory the career here – the list already happened on slide 3.

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Trajectories

Tonight ours came together here.

Thank you.

ITEM 1d, the end of the introduction. Grateful to all who want to share, all who facilitate, all who come to experience. LET THE THANK-YOU LAND. Pause before moving. It is the warmest moment in the first half and rushing it costs the rest.



ITEM 2, 0:45. The outline in four words, delivered fast. Do NOT expand any of them. It is supposed to make sense in retrospect.

ITEM 3, 1:30. The flip, and the thesis. It is an apology — the story died on the way over. Turn it: tonight it is not an apology, it is the condition of the room. NEEDS FROM HIM: the opening twenty seconds, an instance of the phrase actually failing. Still open.

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ITEM 4a, 2:30. WHAT SHE DID: took a genuinely horrible situation and made it funny by putting the room, momentarily, inside the heads of the people involved. Her own hook does this talk's flip three years early – most people hear Donner Party and think cannibalism, valid, but that only scratches the surface. Do not explain why it matters. That happens at Mars.



ITEM 4b, 0:30. Read the title aloud. Stop. Add nothing – it is already funnier than any gloss. FIRST CUT IF RUNNING LONG. One frame, thirty seconds, the only genuinely optional beat in the talk.

ITEM 5, 0:45. THE HINGE. Name the recursion out loud, as the joke it is: you were not at any of those. Often the speaker was not at the thing either – Berlioz has been dead since 1869. A talk called You Had to be There just spent three minutes on second- and third-hand material, and it worked. *** ASK IT AND DO NOT ANSWER IT. *** Resolve the why here and Mars becomes a restatement and the middle of the talk goes flat for two minutes. NEEDS FROM HIM: exact wording, which must not contain its own answer.



ITEM 6a. Neither of those is in the data stream. Do not rush this one – it is the only abstract beat in the talk and it buys both of the next two.

ITEM 6b. The thesis as mechanism, said once, flat: it is where the people are that the cognition happens. Say it once. Do not elaborate. Next beat.

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ITEM 7, 1:30. Long-time friend of Wolverine Farm who used to watch the Nerd Nite crowd assemble. Approached Senne one evening, was soon on the calendar. REASON, ONE LINE, PAST TENSE: we want to platform people who want to talk – connect speakers and audience, not filter them. Then John on stage as himself. Great talk. *** DO NOT READ HIS ABSTRACT ALOUD. *** That makes John the joke in front of other bosses. The beat needs the decision, not the exhibit. WHY HERE: Mars invites "so transmit better." This is the counter-example. The edit that would have made it clearer would have removed John from it. OPTIONAL, ONE SENTENCE, HIS CALL: same mechanism as the HoloLens spec bug – a legible restatement silently becomes the reference.

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ITEM 8a. As Joel talked through the parts – wind supply, keys, pipes – his assistants and THE AUDIENCE assembled them into a working instrument.



ITEM 8b. THE LANDING. The only moment of real feeling in the talk. Joel is a professor, a composer, a working musician. He sat down and brought it to life. SAY ONCE, FLAT, THEN STOP: it connected me to the music in a way I had never felt before. *** NO SECOND SENTENCE. *** The explanation is the sentimentality that kills it. The pause does the work. *** DO NOT GENERALISE. *** Not ”and that’s what Nerd Nite does.” No instruction to the room, not once. Say ”a volunteer,” not ”an audience member.” Mars inverted: there the instrument goes and the people stay home, and the chronicle comes back incomplete. Here the people built the instrument and stayed in the room. Same notes. Same physics. Identical data.

ITEM 9, 0:30. THE CLOSE. Screen deliberately empty – no logo, no bug, nothing. A slide reading "You are." would do the work for him and rob it. NEEDS FROM HIM: the twenty seconds before the turn, carrying the room from the organ to stillness. THEN: You had to be there. You are. NOTHING AFTER IT. No thank-you inside the talk – that was slide 5. No call to action. Stop talking.

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CREDITS. *** DO NOT SHOW THIS DURING THE TALK. *** Slide 16 is blank and the talk ends there, on five words, with nothing after it. Advance to this one when the first question comes, and leave it up for the whole Q&A. That way the thanks are generous and unhurried and never compete with the close. If Berlioz got cut for time, Matt Browne stays on this slide anyway.